

By Ambreesh Mishra

A day after the Taliban blew up the shrine of 17th century Sufi poet Rehman Baba at Peshawar in Pakistan on March 5, the muted outcry at a Khanqah (spiritual retreat) in the walled city of Bhopal could barely be heard in the narrow alleyways. But the message sent out by the gathering of devout Sufis in Tila Jamalpura locality of the Madhya Pradesh capital was loud and clear: they were reclaiming their space amid the tide of militant Islamism, willing Allah to reform hardliners, or destroy them.

The next Jumerat (Thursday), it was business as usual in the Khanqah. An assorted gathering of Muslim Chishtiyas and their Hindu neighbours was back singing a quaint hymn that blends, as they claim, the best of the Vedas with the Quran. Harilal Sahu, a practicing Hindu neighbour aware of the practice says, "I wish more Muslims would follow the lead of the Chishtiyas." He need not fret over the perceived trend of rising Wahabism or Talibanisation of Indian Muslims. The Sufi sect, or the Chishtiya Silsila as they like to call themselves, is making a strong comeback in these parts, with more than a little help from ordinary Hindus.

In Bhopal, the sharply declining water level of the Upper Lake came a godsend for the Chishtiyas. The dwindling water opened up a land route to the shrine of Hazrat Shah Ali Shah Data Chishti on an island. Walking to the shrine with the Chishtiya Muslims during the Urs were cash-rich Hindus Sarafa businessmen who lingered at the shrine till dawn.

Last year, some Muslim hardliners tried to disrupt a chadar ceremony at the Dargah of Hazrat Roshan Ali Shah at Chandan Nagar in Indore. Local Hindus gathered in force and made them beat a hasty retreat. During the annual Urs at the same shrine about seven months back, another attempt was similarly thwarted by the administration. A spate of such incidents is slowly turning Indore into

PANKAJ TIWARI



A Matter of FAITH

The Chishtiya Silsila makes a comeback in central India despite renewed opposition from religious hardliners

a communal tinderbox.

From small towns in Malwa like Burhanpur and Dhar to Gwalior and places like Sagar in Bundelkhand and Rewa in Baghelkhand, the Chishtiya sect is becoming more visible. The Urs at the dargahs of prominent Sufi saints are becoming louder and more colourful and the qawwali is returning with a vengeance despite the pronouncements of orthodox outfits. The district administration of Raizen estimates that the six-day Urs at the shrine of Peer Fatehullah Shah in

April attracted four lakh devotees.

Most of the Chishtiyas draw their following from the Sunni Muslim sect and thus bear the brunt of rising hard-line Islam the most. "There was a trend of rising extremism among youths till about four years back. That is now on the wane," says Rashid Khanooni, the Sajjadanashin of the prominent Dargah of Hazrat Khwaja Khanon Saheb in Gwalior. His efforts and stature stymied an effort by some Wahabi hardliners to hold an Ijtima-like religious congregation at Gwalior